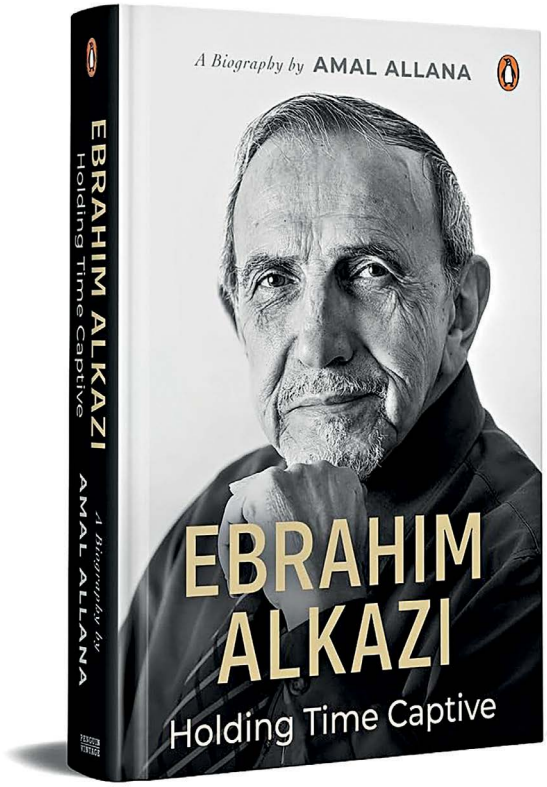


EBRAHIM ALKAZ: Holding Time Captive
by Amal Allana
PENGUIN VINTAGE
₹1,299; 672 pages

BOOKS

A DRAMATIC LIFE

***Written by his daughter, this biography humanises the towering cultural figure that was* Ebrahim Alkazi**

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India's Ebrahim Alkazi was one of the truly great generative cultural figures of post-Independence India. Born into a wealthy family, he made maximum use of his good fortune, uniting that with sharply intelligent hard work to contribute massively, particularly in the fields of theatre and the visual arts. Beginning his career in Bombay during that city's most fecund period as India's cultural capital, he then moved to Delhi, becoming instrumental in transforming the bureaucratic backwater into a zone of huge artistic dynamism. For those of us who grew up in the decades between 1960 and 1980, Alkazi was already a legend, someone who seemed to be sitting at a great unreachable height atop the country's cultural peaks.

Written by his daughter Amal Allana, this biography humanises Alkazi, allowing us to accompany an ambitious but hungrily curious young man as he follows his heart to pursue a career in the arts. Reading the book you realise yet again how the life-choices made by someone like Alkazi were neither common nor inevitable. You also understand how artistic obsession and intellectual flexibility sometimes create their own good fortune, leading to the production of truly transformative work.

The book is written in the 'fictionalised biography' style that is now quite popular. However, since she herself is a leading theatre practitioner, Allana also manages to engage lucidly with the ideas, concepts and challenges as Alkazi discovers them across his life. Fairly early in the book, as we're exploring the milieu of amateur English theatre in war-time Bombay, the young Ebrahim and Roshen Padamsee fall in love and get married. From this point on, the book becomes a twin biography of Allana's parents, with equal weight and sympathy being given to both protagonists' points of view. While this is largely an admiring account written by a loving daughter, this double story (which also takes us through Roshen and Ebrahim's painful break-up) helps navigate the book away from the reefs of simplistic hagiography.

Allana engages lucidly with the ideas, concepts and challenges as Alkazi discovers them across his life

For those of us interested in the histories of the Indian metropolis in the 20th century, the volume is a treasure trove, taking us through vividly (if sometimes over-written) passages into different scenes: a bookshop in 1920s Poona, the crowd at Gowalia Tank during Gandhi's Quit India speech, the young Alkazi couple's rented flat in early 1950s London, a few years later the process of decorating a large, new South Bombay apartment in a modern idiom, an empty Greek amphitheatre, a Standard Herald car driving in 1970s Delhi and so on. As a record of the history and the thinking that powered one of the biggest tributaries that went into forming what one could call 'Modern Indian' theatre, the book is a priceless resource. For those yet to become familiar with the long-gone milieus that helped the art scene in urban India become truly cosmopolitan and unique, a depth and sophistication we take for granted even as we dismantle it, this book will be an eye-opener. ■

–Ruchir Joshi